

The AI Enablement Playbook

Every company just bought AI. Almost none of them have figured out how to use it. That gap is a job — and you can start doing it from the seat you're already in.

by d.avebrown

There's a role opening up inside basically every company right now, and it's not the one everyone's chasing. It's not "AI engineer." It's not "ML researcher." It's not "prompt wizard." And it's definitely not "the person who tells everyone to use ChatGPT and calls it a transformation."

It's **AI enablement** — helping real teams, doing real work, actually use this stuff. That sounds soft. It isn't. It's quietly becoming one of the most valuable jobs in the modern workplace, and here's the uncomfortable reason why.

Most companies already have AI. They have licenses, pilots, a memo from the CEO about productivity, and a handful of people in every department poking at ChatGPT or Copilot. What they *don't* have is adoption. Redesigned workflows. Clear rules. Confident employees. Managers who know what to automate, what to augment, and what to leave the hell alone. The tools showed up. The change didn't.

Deloitte's 2026 State of AI in the Enterprise report puts numbers on it: companies expanded worker access to sanctioned AI tools by roughly 50% in a single year — but access didn't turn into usage. Only 25% of organizations had moved 40% or more of their experiments into production, though 54% expected to hit that mark within three to six months. Translation: everyone's moving fast and stuck at the same time.

The bottleneck isn't the technology. It's adoption, training, workflow design, trust, governance, and plain old change management. That's the whole opportunity — and the good news is you don't need a title to start filling it. You need a playbook. Here's mine.

THE MENTAL MODEL

Access is not enablement. The gap between them is the job.

Enablement is turning scattered experiments into repeatable behavior.

Most AI use inside companies today is random. Someone tries a clever prompt. Someone gets Claude to rewrite an email. Someone summarizes a meeting. Useful — but it evaporates the second that person logs off. It lives in one head and dies in one chat thread.

Enablement is what happens when that stops being an accident. It's when a team can answer, out loud and consistently: what parts of our work are good candidates for AI, what tools are approved, what data is safe to use, what still needs a human, where it saves time, where it creates risk, and how we'd even know if it's working. That's a fundamentally different skill than "being good at AI."

THE ONE IDEA TO HOLD ONTO

Plenty of people are good at playing with AI. Very few are good at getting a nervous, busy, skeptical team to actually change how they work. The second thing is the career. The first thing is a hobby.

WHY NOW

The tools are here. The transformation isn't. Someone has to close it.

Companies are bracing for automation they haven't designed for yet.

Deloitte found 34% of organizations using AI to deeply transform products or business models, and another 30% redesigning key processes around it — but 37% are still using AI at a surface level, with little or no change to how the work is actually done. Tools bought, habits unchanged.

The number that should make you sit up: 84% of companies have *not* redesigned jobs around AI — even though 36% expect at least 10% of their jobs to be fully automated within a year, and 82% expect that within three years. They're bracing for impact and steering with their knees. Someone has to actually do the redesign, and it won't only be engineers, executives, or consultants with pretty decks. It'll be people who can sit between the business, the tools, the process, and the humans.

READ THE ROOM

"We expect AI to change a third of our jobs" and "we have not changed a single job" are both true at most companies right now. The person who can turn the first sentence into a plan is the one who gets funded.

THE BIG MISREAD

This is a translation job, not an engineering job

The hard part was never "can the tool do something cool."

People hear "AI" and assume the role has to be deeply technical. Parts can be — if you're wiring up agents, APIs, or data pipelines. But the enablement side is mostly translation. Can you understand what the business is trying to do? Map how the work actually gets done today? Spot where AI fits and, more importantly, where it doesn't? Teach someone without making them feel stupid? Calm the fear without lying about the disruption?

That's product thinking, onboarding, operations, customer success, change management, and internal comms — not backpropagation. If you've ever gotten a room full of busy people to adopt a new piece of software, you already own the hardest muscle in this job. The tool doing something interesting is easy. Getting people to trust it, use it right, and change their Tuesday is the whole game.

WHO'S ALREADY HALFWAY THERE

Five backgrounds with a real head start

01 — Product Managers

PMs already live between users, business goals, and engineering constraints — which is exactly the AI enablement battlefield. You know how to ask "what problem, which user, what's the current workflow, how do we measure success." The trap: over-indexing on tool selection and roadmap while under-investing in training and the messy human adoption. Deciding what should exist is not the same as getting people to use it.

02 — Customer Success & Onboarding

The most underrated background on this list. Your entire job has been moving people from "I technically have a login" to "I actually know how this helps me" — which is the exact problem every company now has with AI. You know how to handle resistance, explain software in plain English, spot where people get stuck, and build onboarding that repeats without you in the room. That last part *is* enablement.

03 — Support Leads

Support sees the real pain — the repeated questions, the broken processes, the weird edge cases — often faster than any executive. That makes you great at spotting genuine use cases. Just don't pitch "replace support with bots." The mature version asks: which workflows can AI assist, which answers can it draft, which repetitive tickets should've been documentation, and which escalations still need human judgment.

04 — Operations

Ops people understand process, and process is everything here — because AI dropped onto a broken process just gives you a faster broken process. Here's the line worth tattooing on the wall: *humans make tiny judgment calls that quietly keep broken processes alive; AI usually can't*. A person works around missing fields, inconsistent names, and undocumented exceptions. AI exposes all of it. Your edge isn't knowing every model — it's knowing how work actually moves.

05 — Trainers, Educators & Internal Comms

Companies don't just need tools; they need AI literacy — practical, not abstract. Not "here's what a large language model is," but "here's how sales preps a call, here's how finance reviews variance, here's how a manager preps a one-on-one without turning into a surveillance goblin." That last bit matters: enablement isn't just enthusiasm. It's judgment about where the tool belongs and where it doesn't.

ENABLEMENT VS. THEATER

Great enablement is boring, specific, and measured.

You can spot the real thing by five signs. **People know what they're allowed to use AI for** — they're not guessing or quietly pasting customer data into random tools. **Training is role-specific** — marketing gets marketing examples, nobody sits through a generic "AI 101" and pretends it changed anything. **Teams have reusable workflows, not just prompts. Managers understand how the work is changing** — including the honest question of what happens to the five hours AI just freed up. And **adoption is measured** in business terms: faster cycles, better answers, fewer errors, more confidence.

PROMPT VS. WORKFLOW — KNOW THE DIFFERENCE

A prompt is: "summarize this."

A workflow is: "Every Friday, CS exports at-risk accounts, AI summarizes each one's support history and flags renewal risk, drafts next steps, and a human CSM approves the plan before anything goes out." One is a party trick. The other is a system.

The dangerous version: hype, demos, and nothing that survives contact.

The bad version of this role shows up with slides and energy. Runs a few workshops, teaches prompting, says "AI will change everything," makes a spreadsheet of use cases, launches five pilots — and then nothing changes. This is the proof-of-concept trap, and Deloitte names it plainly: pilots run in clean, isolated environments with small teams, but production demands integration, security review, compliance, monitoring, and maintenance. That's where experiments go to die. Your value isn't demoing a cool tool. It's moving demo → workflow → measurable impact.

THE THREE SKILLS

1. AI Fluency — be meaningfully ahead of the average employee

You don't need to be an ML researcher. You need to know what's possible and where it breaks. Get fluent with the major tools, understand how prompting works in real workflows, how to judge output quality, how agents differ from chatbots, how retrieval and internal docs change the answers, where hallucinations creep in, when human review is non-negotiable, and what should never be pasted into a public tool. Know what "good enough" means for a low-risk task versus a high-risk one. You don't need everything — you need a real edge over the median coworker.

2. Process Thinking — the part the hobbyists skip

Before you recommend AI, you should be able to map the current process: what triggers the work, who touches it, what systems are involved, what decisions get made, where it gets stuck, what gets reviewed and approved, and what happens when it goes wrong. *Only then* ask whether AI belongs. Sometimes the honest answer is no — the fix is a better form, cleaner data, or standardizing the process before you ever touch a model. That restraint is where your credibility comes from. Serious enablement people improve the work, not sprinkle AI on it.

3. Change Management — the most important one

People are scared, and a lot of that fear is rational — they read the same automation headlines the executives do. So you cannot walk in and say "don't worry, this won't affect your job." They won't believe you, and they probably shouldn't. The better message: *"Yes, this changes the work. That's exactly why we need to be the ones shaping how it changes."* Empathy without denial. Teaching without condescending. Pushing without bulldozing.

THE STARTER KIT

Don't wait for the title. Start doing the work from your current seat.

Step 1 — Pick one annoying workflow

Not "transform the company." One annoying, frequent, text-heavy task with a predictable output, a human still reviewing the result, and manageable risk. Think: summarizing calls, drafting follow-ups, turning meeting notes into action items, categorizing feedback, writing release notes from tickets, prepping sales briefs. **Do not start** with legal, medical, financial approvals, HR terminations, or anything where a bad output hurts someone. Boring and low-risk is the point.

Step 2 — Map the workflow before you add AI

Write down who does it, how often, how long it takes, the inputs, the outputs, who reviews it, where it stalls, what "good" looks like, and the mistakes that repeat. This is the move that separates serious enablement from random prompting. "AI can help with this" is a shrug. "This takes 90 minutes, happens three times a week, and fails at these two points" is something you can actually improve — and prove.

Step 3 — Build a simple assisted version

Not a product. Not a platform. A better way to do the one task, designed so AI assists and the human keeps the judgment.

THE SHAPE OF A GOOD FIRST WORKFLOW

Input: customer call transcript

AI task: summarize pain points, action items, risks, and a draft follow-up email

Human task: review, edit, send

Output: a cleaner follow-up in a fraction of the time

Step 4 — Test with two or three real people

Not the whole company. Two or three people who actually do the work. Watch where they get confused, ask what they don't trust, ask whether it saves time or just creates a new thing to babysit. AI workflows tend to look brilliant to the person who built them and awkward to the person using them on a chaotic Tuesday afternoon. Find that out now, cheaply.

Step 5 — Measure before and after

Keep it simple: time before, time after, how much editing was needed, how often the output was usable, how confident users felt, what still needs a human. You're not just playing with a tool — you're building proof that you can drive adoption. That proof is career capital, and almost nobody bothers to collect it.

Step 6 — Package it so it works without you

A one-page guide, a short Loom, a reusable prompt, a "when to use this" checklist, a "never paste this" list, a couple of good-vs-bad output examples, and a tiny FAQ. The moment other people can run the workflow without you in the room, you've stopped using AI and started *enabling* it. That's the whole promotion in one sentence.

Step 7 — Share the win like an adult, not a hype account

COPY THIS INTERNAL NOTE

"We tested an AI-assisted workflow for summarizing customer calls. The goal wasn't full automation — it was cutting manual recap time while keeping human review. In a small test it dropped first-draft time from ~X to ~Y minutes, and the team found it most useful for action items and follow-up emails. Recommended next step: test with five more users and build a version tuned for account managers."

No hype, no fear, no "AI changes everything." Just practical, measured, honest. That tone is what makes leadership start seeing you as the person for this.

FIVE PORTFOLIO PROJECTS

Strong first builds, internal or freelance

1. Meeting → Action

Take a transcript, extract decisions, owners, deadlines, risks, and open questions, generate a clean follow-up, human reviews before sending. Low risk, instantly understood, useful across nearly every team. The perfect first win.

2. Customer Feedback Synthesizer

Feedback is scattered across tickets, calls, emails, reviews, and Slack. Pull a sample, cluster by theme, severity, and segment, ship a weekly "voice of customer" report. Proves AI can turn messy qualitative sludge into an actual business insight — and product, support, and leadership all want it.

3. Internal Knowledge Assistant

Gather existing docs, find the gaps and stale material, build an approved FAQ or assistant with source links, human owners maintain it. Teaches the lesson that carries the whole field: *AI is only as good as the information it can reach.*

4. Sales Prep Assistant

Pull account notes, CRM history, recent emails, support issues, and appropriate public research into a call brief with likely pain points and discovery angles; rep reviews before the call. Clear productivity value, easy to measure, a clean example of AI augmenting a human instead of replacing one.

5. Policy Explainer

Nobody reads the long policy. Turn an approved one into plain-English summaries, role-specific examples, and "can I do this?" scenarios, with links back to the source. Great for HR, compliance, IT, and security — and it shows enablement isn't only about speed. It can reduce risk and increase understanding at the same time.

POSITIONING

Become useful before you announce yourself

Don't declare yourself "the AI person." Show up with results.

The title-first move backfires. The credibility-first move doesn't. Start saying things like: "I tested a safer way to use AI for this workflow." "I mapped the current process and found two spots where AI helps without removing human review." "I'd like to run a small pilot with three people and measure whether it saves time." And the most powerful one of all — *"I think this is a case where automation beats AI"* — or even "this isn't an AI problem, it's a broken-process problem." Executives are drowning in hype. The person who can separate signal from noise gets trusted immediately.

IF YOUR COMPANY IS SLOW, BUILD PROOF OUTSIDE IT

Help a small business, nonprofit, or creator — but never pitch "AI transformation." Pitch an outcome: "I can turn your customer emails into organized follow-up tasks." "I can help you summarize sales calls and draft the follow-ups." A few small projects become case studies — each one documenting the problem, the old workflow, the assisted workflow, the human review step, the tools, the measurable result, and the risks you considered. That beats "I took a course" every time.

RED FLAGS

The five ways people torch their own credibility

01 — Treating AI as the answer to everything

Sometimes the fix is a checklist, a cleaner database, a policy, a dashboard, or a manager finally making a call they've been dodging. AI is powerful. It is not a substitute for operational clarity, and pretending otherwise is how you get quietly ignored.

02 — Dismissing the fear

People aren't stupid for being nervous — they know automation is coming for some tasks. Wave that away and you lose the room. Acknowledge it and pull them into shaping the workflow instead.

03 — Confusing demos with adoption

A cool demo is not a changed process. A changed process is when people use the workflow when you're not in the room. That's the only finish line that counts.

04 — Skipping governance

Telling people to paste customer data, contracts, or financials into random tools isn't enablement — it's liability with a friendly face. This matters more as agents arrive: Deloitte found nearly three in four companies plan to deploy agentic AI within two years, but only 21% have a mature governance model for autonomous agents. Know enough about data privacy, sensitivity, and human approval to not be dangerous — and you'll be taken far more seriously than the person who only knows prompts.

05 — Measuring vibes

"It felt useful" is not evidence. Measure time saved, quality improved, errors caught, response time cut, confidence raised, adoption rate. Even rough numbers beat vibes — and they're what turns a nice pilot into a funded program.

THE 90-DAY PIVOT

A concrete plan you can start Monday

DAYS 1-15 · LEARN & OBSERVE

Pick two AI tools and use them daily until they're second nature. Study your own team's workflows. Write down five text-heavy, repetitive use cases. Find your company's AI policy — if there isn't a clear one, that's a risk worth noting. Launch nothing yet. Goal: understand where AI could actually help.

DAYS 16-30 · PICK ONE WORKFLOW

Choose one low-risk workflow. Map the current process, talk to the people who do it, estimate the time it eats, define what "better" looks like, and build a simple assisted version — with the human review step baked in. Goal: a small, safe pilot.

DAYS 31-45 · TEST WITH A TINY GROUP

Two or three people. Watch them use it, collect feedback, tighten the prompt and the instructions, document what works and what doesn't. Goal: evidence, not perfection.

DAYS 46-60 · PACKAGE IT

Short guide, short demo, checklist, safety rules, examples, and clear "do not use this for" guidance. Goal: make it usable without you personally explaining it every time.

DAYS 61-75 · MEASURE & SHARE

Compare before and after: time saved, output quality, where human review mattered, what risks surfaced, whether users would keep using it. Share the results with your manager. Goal: become visible as someone who improves work with AI responsibly.

DAYS 76-90 · EXPAND CAREFULLY

Pick one path: improve the original, adapt it for another team, or take on a second use case. Don't sprint. Enablement credibility is built from small wins that survive contact with reality.

The Honest Pitch

No, you're not going to become an "AI Enablement Executive" tomorrow — and anyone selling you that is selling you something. But you can start walking the path today. Tools will change, models will change, vendors will change. The durable skill is helping humans and organizations adapt to new capabilities, and that skill compounds.

Become the person on your team who understands the tools better than most, who spots the practical use cases, who builds the simple workflows, who teaches others, and — crucially — who knows when *not* to use AI. Someone who helps people adopt new ways of working without making them feel replaced, stupid, or left behind. That's the lane. Not AI hype. Not AI panic. AI enablement. And the best time to start building proof is before the title becomes obvious.

Want more on building an AI-native career?

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